subterranean passage or other access to Hades there – and therefore judges the legend to be false. This marks the dawn of a new era.

This new approach to knowledge works quickly and impressively. Within a matter of a few years, Anaximander understands that the Earth floats in the sky and the sky continues beneath the Earth; that rainwater comes from the evaporation of water on Earth; that the variety of substances in the world must be susceptible to being understood in terms of a single, unitary and simple constituent, which he calls *apeiron*, the indistinct; that the animals and plants evolve and adapt to changes in the environment, and that man must have evolved from other animals. Thus, gradually, was founded the basis of a grammar for understanding the world which is substantially still our own today.

Situated at a point of conjunction between the emergent Greek civilization and the ancient empires of Mesopotamia and Egypt, nourished by their knowledge but immersed in the liberty and the political fluidity which is typically Greek; in a social space without imperial palaces, or powerful priestly castes, where individual citizens discuss their destinies in open agoras, Miletus is the place where, for the first time, men decide collectively their own laws; where the first parliament in the history of the world gathers – the *Panionium*, meeting-place of the delegates of the Ionian League – and where for the first time men doubt that only the gods are capable of accounting for the mysteries of the world. Through discussion, it is possible to reach the best decisions for the community; through discussion, it is possible to understand the world. This is the immense legacy of Miletus, cradle of philosophy, of the natural sciences, and of geographical and historical studies. It is no exaggeration to say that the entire scientific and philosophical tradition, Mediterranean and then modern, has a crucial root in the speculations of the thinkers of Miletus in the sixth century BCE.[1]

This luminous Miletus shortly afterwards came to a calamitous end. The arrival of the Persian Empire, and a failed anti-imperial revolt, led to a ferocious destruction of the city in 494 BCE and to the enslavement of a large number of its inhabitants. In Athens, the poet Phrynichus writes the tragedy *The Taking of Miletus*, which so deeply moves the Athenians that its re-staging is prohibited, on account of it causing too much distress. But twenty years later, the Greeks repel the Persian menace; Miletus is reborn, repopulated, and returned to being a centre of commerce and ideas, radiating its thought and spirit once more.

The person with whom we began this chapter must have been moved by this spirit when, in 450, according to tradition, he embarked from Miletus for Abdera. His name was Leucippus. Little is known about his life.[2] He wrote a book entitled *The Great Cosmology*. On his arrival in Abdera, he founded a